

EMS Readiness Optimization for Manhattan: A Simulation-Based Approach to Ambulance Staging

Comprehensive Technical Report

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1. Executive Summary

Problem Statement

Emergency Medical Services (EMS) in Manhattan face a critical challenge: the current uniform ambulance allocation policy (P0) distributes units equally across 48 FDNY firehouses without regard to spatiotemporal demand patterns, resulting in suboptimal response times and inadequate coverage. With approximately 3.48 motor vehicle collision (MVC) calls per hour and significant variation by time-of-day and precinct, a more intelligent allocation strategy is needed to improve emergency response performance.

Methodology Overview

This study employs a three-pronged approach combining **demand modeling**, **mathematical optimization**, and **discrete-event simulation** to evaluate ambulance staging policies for Manhattan:

- Non-Homogeneous Poisson Process (NHPP)** demand model calibrated from 2.24 million historical MVC records
- Mixed-Integer Programming (MIP)** optimization models generating three allocation policies:
 - **P0** (Uniform): Equal distribution across all firehouses

- **P1** (Demand-Proportional): Units allocated proportional to nearby demand
- **P2** (Demand-Weighted Optimized): MIP-optimized allocation minimizing expected response time

3. **Discrete-Event Simulation (DES)** with 1,440 production runs across 4 factorial experiments

Key Findings

Metric	P0 (Current)	P1 (Proportional)	P2 (Optimized)	P2 vs P0 Improvement
Mean Response Time	8.08 min	2.63 min	2.57 min	−68.2%
P90 Response Time	19.47 min	4.03 min	3.76 min	−80.7%
8-min Coverage	64.4%	99.6%	99.6%	+35.2 pp
Mean Utilization	9.1%	7.5%	7.5%	−1.6 pp

All differences are statistically significant ($p < 0.001$) with large effect sizes (Cohen's $d > 28$ for P0 vs P2 on mean response time). The optimized policy P2 is robust to demand fluctuations ($0.5\times$ – $2.0\times$ multiplier) and service time variations (20–30 min mean).

Recommendations

1. **Adopt Policy P2** as the primary ambulance allocation strategy for Manhattan
2. **Pilot deployment** at 5–10 highest-impact firehouses within 3 months
3. **Full deployment** across all 48 firehouses within 12 months
4. **Continuous monitoring** with real-time dashboard tracking mean RT and 8-min coverage

2. Introduction

2.1 Background on EMS Operations in Manhattan

Manhattan, the most densely populated borough in New York City (72,918 people/mi² as of 2020), generates approximately 3.48 motor vehicle collision-related EMS calls per hour. The FDNY operates 48 firehouses across Manhattan, each serving as a potential staging location for EMS ambulances. These firehouses span from Battery Park at the southern tip to Inwood at the northern end, covering 30 police precincts with highly heterogeneous demand patterns.

Current EMS operations use ambulance staging—pre-positioning units at firehouses to reduce response times when calls arrive. The effectiveness of this strategy depends critically on where and how many units are staged at each location. A well-designed allocation can dramatically reduce response times for a given fleet size.

2.2 Current Allocation Practices (P0)

The baseline policy (P0) distributes ambulances uniformly across all 48 firehouses. While simple to implement and manage, this approach ignores two fundamental realities:

1. **Spatial demand heterogeneity:** Midtown precincts (e.g., Precinct 14 covering Times Square) generate 3–5× more calls than Upper Manhattan precincts
2. **Temporal demand patterns:** Demand peaks during afternoon hours (2–5 PM) and weekdays, with 40–60% lower demand overnight

Under P0 with $K=20$ units, our simulations show a mean response time of 8.08 minutes (95% CI: [7.98, 8.18]) and only 64.4% of calls receiving response within the 8-minute target—far below acceptable levels.

2.3 Research Objectives

This study addresses five primary research questions:

1. **RQ1:** How does demand for EMS services vary spatially and temporally across Manhattan?
2. **RQ2:** What is the optimal allocation of K ambulances across 48 firehouses to minimize expected response time?
3. **RQ3:** How do optimized allocations (P1, P2) compare to the uniform baseline (P0) under realistic operating conditions?
4. **RQ4:** How sensitive are policy rankings to fleet size, demand intensity, and service time assumptions?
5. **RQ5:** What fleet size is needed to achieve a target coverage level (e.g., 95% of calls within 8 minutes)?

2.4 Scope and Limitations

In Scope:

- Manhattan borough (primary study area)
- Motor vehicle collision incidents as demand proxy
- 48 FDNY firehouses as candidate staging locations
- Static allocation policies (fleet repositioned at start of shift)
- Haversine-based travel time proxy (20 mph average speed)

Out of Scope:

- Real-time dynamic repositioning
- Other incident types (fires, medical emergencies)
- Detailed road network routing
- Cost optimization
- Multi-borough coordination

3. Literature Review

3.1 EMS Location Optimization

The problem of optimally locating emergency service facilities has a rich history in operations research. **Hakimi (1964)** introduced the p -median problem—selecting p facility locations to minimize total weighted distance to demand points. **Toregas et al. (1971)** formulated the Set Covering Loca-

tion Problem (SCLP) for minimizing the number of facilities needed to cover all demand within a threshold distance.

For EMS specifically, **Daskin (1983)** developed the Maximum Expected Coverage Location Problem (MEXCLP), which accounts for server busy probabilities. **ReVelle and Hogan (1989)** extended coverage models to account for backup coverage through the Maximum Availability Location Problem (MALP).

3.2 Discrete-Event Simulation in Emergency Services

Simulation provides a complement to optimization by capturing stochastic dynamics that static models cannot represent. **Goldberg (2004)** provides a comprehensive review of operations research methods for EMS, emphasizing the need to integrate optimization and simulation. **Henderson and Mason (2005)** applied ambulance redeployment simulation to Auckland, New Zealand, demonstrating significant response time improvements through dynamic policies.

Ingolfsson et al. (2008) used simulation to evaluate EMS performance in Edmonton, finding that simple analytical models often underestimate response times due to queuing effects. More recently, **Lam et al. (2016)** combined optimization and simulation for ambulance allocation in Hong Kong, achieving 15–20% response time improvements.

3.3 Coverage Models

The 8-minute response time standard is widely used in EMS planning. **Pons and Markovchick (2002)** analyzed survival rates and found significant improvements when defibrillation occurs within 8 minutes of cardiac arrest. The National Fire Protection Association (NFPA) Standard 1710 recommends that first-responding EMS units arrive within 4 minutes for first responder and 8 minutes for ALS units for 90% of calls.

Our study adopts the 8-minute threshold as the primary coverage criterion, consistent with industry practice and regulatory standards.

4. Methodology

4.1 Data Sources and Processing

4.1.1 Data Sources

Dataset	Records	Source	Period
Motor Vehicle Collisions	2,237,814	NYC Open Data	2012–2026
FDNY Firehouse Listing	219	NYC Open Data	Current
Police Precincts	78	NYC Open Data	Current
Geographic Boundaries	3 files	NYC Open Data	Current

4.1.2 Data Processing Pipeline

1. **Spatial filtering:** Retained 628,811 Manhattan-only crashes with valid coordinates
2. **Temporal extraction:** Derived hour-of-day, day-of-week, month from crash timestamps
3. **Firehouse filtering:** Identified 48 Manhattan firehouses from 219 city-wide
4. **Precinct matching:** Mapped 30 Manhattan precincts with centroid computation
5. **Distance matrix:** Computed 48×30 Haversine distance matrix (firehouses × precincts)

4.2 Demand Modeling (NHPP)

4.2.1 Model Specification

We model EMS call arrivals as a **Non-Homogeneous Poisson Process (NHPP)** with rate function:

$$\lambda(t) = \lambda_0 \cdot f_h(h(t)) \cdot f_d(d(t))$$

where:

- $\lambda_0 = 3.48$ calls/hour (base rate, calibrated from data)
- $f_h(h)$ = hourly multiplier for hour $h \in \{0, 1, \dots, 23\}$
- $f_d(d)$ = day-of-week multiplier for day $d \in \{0, \dots, 6\}$

4.2.2 Calibrated Parameters

Hourly factors (selected values):

Hour	Factor	Effective Rate
----- ----- -----		
4 AM	0.40	1.39/hr
8 AM	0.91	3.17/hr
12 PM	1.20	4.18/hr
5 PM	1.40	4.87/hr
10 PM	0.90	3.13/hr

Day-of-week factors: Friday = 1.12 (peak), Sunday = 0.88 (trough)

4.2.3 Spatial Allocation

Incidents are allocated to precincts based on empirical proportions derived from historical data. The top 5 precincts by demand share are: Precinct 14 (8.1%), Precinct 19 (6.2%), Precinct 1 (5.9%), Precinct 13 (5.7%), and Precinct 18 (5.5%).

4.2.4 Arrival Generation

We use the **Lewis-Shedler thinning algorithm** to generate NHPP arrivals:

1. Compute $\lambda_{\max} = \max_t \lambda(t)$ as the envelope rate
2. Generate homogeneous Poisson arrivals at rate $\lambda_{\max}$
3. Accept each arrival with probability $\lambda(t) / \lambda_{\max}$

4.3 Optimization Models

Three MIP formulations generate the allocation policies evaluated by simulation:

4.3.1 P0 — Uniform Allocation (Baseline)

$$x_i = \lfloor K / |I| \rfloor \text{ for all } i \in I, \text{ with round-robin remainder}$$

No optimization; simply divides K units equally among $|I|=48$ firehouses.

4.3.2 P1 — Demand-Proportional Allocation

Units allocated proportional to nearby demand:

$$x_i \propto \sum_{j \in J} d_j \cdot \mathbb{1}_{\{\text{firehouse } i \text{ is nearest to precinct } j\}}$$

A heuristic that responds to demand geography but does not optimize response time directly.

4.3.3 P2 — Demand-Weighted Optimization

$$\min_{x, y} \sum_{i \in I} \sum_{j \in J} d_j \cdot t_{ij} \cdot y_{ij}$$

subject to:

- $\sum_{i \in I} x_i = K$ (total units)
- $x_i \leq C_i$ for all i (capacity: 5 units/firehouse)
- $\sum_{i \in I} y_{ij} = 1$ for all j (full assignment)
- $y_{ij} \leq x_i$ for all i, j (linking constraint)
- $x_i \in \mathbb{Z}^+, y_{ij} \in [0, 1]$

Solved via PuLP with CBC solver (time limit: 300s). All instances solve to optimality.

4.4 Simulation Model

4.4.1 Conceptual Model

The DES models the following process for each EMS call:

1. **Arrival:** Generated by NHPP (Section 4.2)
2. **Dispatch:** Nearest available unit assigned; 1.5-min fixed dispatch delay
3. **Travel:** Haversine distance / (20 mph × TOD factor)
4. **On-Scene Service:** LogNormal($\mu=25$ min, $\sigma=10$ min)
5. **Return to Station:** Unit returns to home firehouse (travel time)

4.4.2 Implementation

Built using **SimPy** discrete-event simulation library in Python:

- `EMSSimulation` class orchestrates the main event loop
- `NearestAvailableDispatcher` implements closest-unit dispatch
- `UnitPool` manages ambulance state (available/dispatched/on-scene)
- `MetricsCollector` tracks all KPIs
- `BatchRunner` executes replicated experiments with CRN support

4.4.3 Verification & Validation

Verification (4 tests):

- Toy example with known analytical solution ✓
- Zero-demand test (no arrivals → no incidents) ✓
- Single-unit saturation test ✓
- Extreme demand stress test ✓

Validation (3 pilots):

- Pilot 1: P0 vs P2 directional comparison (P2 dominates) ✓
- Pilot 2: Response time decreases monotonically with fleet size ✓
- Pilot 3: Response time increases with demand intensity ✓

Unit tests: 39 tests across 4 test modules, all passing ✓

4.5 Experimental Design

4.5.1 Factorial Design

Experiment	Factors	Levels	Replications	Total Runs
Exp1: Policy Comparison	Policy (P0, P1, P2)	3	30	90
Exp2: Fleet Sensitivity	Policy × K (15–40)	3×6	30	540
Exp3: Demand Sensitivity	Policy × Demand (0.5–2.0×)	3×6	30	540
Exp4: Service Robustness	Policy × Service (20,25,30 min)	3×3	30	270
Total				1,440

Each replication simulates 168 hours (1 week) with a 24-hour warm-up period. Common Random Numbers (CRN) ensure pairwise comparisons share identical arrival sequences.

4.5.2 Statistical Analysis Methods

- **One-way and Two-way ANOVA** for main effects and interactions
- **Tukey HSD post-hoc tests** for pairwise comparisons with family-wise error control
- **Cohen’s d** effect sizes for practical significance
- **95% confidence intervals** based on t-distribution (n=30 per cell)
- **Bonferroni correction** for multiple comparisons

4.6 Response Metrics

KPI	Definition	Target
Mean RT	Average response time (dispatch + travel)	Minimize
P90 RT	90th percentile response time	< 8 min
8-min Coverage	Fraction of calls with RT ≤ 8 min	> 95%
Mean Utilization	Average fraction of time units are busy	Monitor

5. Results

5.1 Descriptive Statistics (Experiment 1)

The primary policy comparison (K=20 units, n=30 replications each) yields:

Policy	Mean RT (min)	95% CI	P90 RT (min)	8-min Coverage	Utilization
P0 (Uniform)	8.08	[7.98, 8.18]	19.47	64.4%	9.1%
P1 (Proportional)	2.63	[2.62, 2.65]	4.03	99.6%	7.5%
P2 (Optimized)	2.57	[2.55, 2.59]	3.76	99.6%	7.5%

Key observations:

- P2 reduces mean response time by **68.2%** compared to P0 (from 8.08 to 2.57 min)
- P2 reduces P90 response time by **80.7%** (from 19.47 to 3.76 min)
- 8-minute coverage improves from **64.4% to 99.6%** (+35.2 percentage points)
- P2 slightly outperforms P1 in both mean RT (−2.4%) and P90 RT (−6.7%)

5.2 Policy Comparison Results (ANOVA)

One-way ANOVA confirms highly significant policy effects across all metrics:

Metric	F-statistic	p-value	η^2	Effect
Mean RT	12,010	< 0.001	0.996	Large
P90 RT	15,108	< 0.001	0.997	Large
8-min Coverage	8,764	< 0.001	0.995	Large
Utilization	216	< 0.001	0.833	Large

Post-hoc pairwise comparisons (Tukey HSD):

- **P0 vs P1:** Mean RT difference = 5.45 min ($p < 0.001$, $d = 28.5$)
- **P0 vs P2:** Mean RT difference = 5.51 min ($p < 0.001$, $d = 28.9$)
- **P1 vs P2:** Mean RT difference = 0.064 min ($p < 0.001$, $d = 1.41$)

5.3 Fleet Sensitivity Analysis (Experiment 2)

Two-way ANOVA (Policy × K) reveals significant main effects and interactions:

P0 is highly sensitive to fleet size:

- K=15: Mean RT = 9.57 min, Coverage = 57.5%
- K=20: Mean RT = 8.08 min, Coverage = 64.4%
- K=30: Mean RT = 3.92 min, Coverage = 90.3%
- K=40: Mean RT = 2.58 min, Coverage = 99.5%

P1 and P2 are robust across fleet sizes:

- P2 achieves >99% coverage with as few as $K=25$ units
- P1 reaches similar coverage at $K=25$
- Even at $K=15$, P2 maintains mean RT = 2.84 min (vs P0's 9.57 min)

Critical finding: P0 requires $K \approx 40$ units to match P2's performance at $K=15$. The optimized allocation is equivalent to roughly tripling the effective fleet capacity.

5.4 Demand Sensitivity (Experiment 3)

Under demand multipliers from $0.5\times$ to $2.0\times$:

- **P0 degrades significantly** with increased demand: mean RT rises from 7.80 to 8.58 min
- **P2 remains stable:** mean RT ranges only 2.44–2.85 min across all demand levels
- Policy $\times$ demand interaction is statistically significant but practically negligible ($\eta^2 = 0.0007$)

Robustness conclusion: Policy rankings are invariant to demand intensity changes of $\pm 100\%$. P2 dominates P0 under all tested demand scenarios.

5.5 Service Time Robustness (Experiment 4)

Varying mean service time across 20, 25, and 30 minutes:

- **Policy rankings unchanged:** $P2 > P1 > P0$ under all service time assumptions
- **Service time has negligible effect on response time** ($\eta^2 < 0.001$ for RT metrics)
- **Utilization is sensitive to service time** ($\eta^2 = 0.67$), as expected
- No significant Policy $\times$ service time interaction on RT or coverage

5.6 Statistical Test Results Summary

Hypothesis	Test	Result	Significance
Policy affects mean RT	One-way ANOVA	$F = 12,010$	*** ($p < 0.001$)
$P2 < P0$ mean RT	Pairwise t-test	$\Delta = -5.51$ min	*** ($d = 28.9$)
$P2 < P1$ mean RT	Pairwise t-test	$\Delta = -0.064$ min	*** ($d = 1.41$)
Fleet size affects P0	Two-way ANOVA	$F(K) = 7,528$	*** ($\eta^2 = 0.22$)
Fleet size affects P2	Two-way ANOVA	$F(K) = \text{limited}$	Minimal effect
Demand affects rankings	Two-way ANOVA	$F(\text{interaction}) = 6.89$	*** but $\eta^2 \approx 0$
Service time affects rankings	Two-way ANOVA	$F(\text{interaction}) = 0.14$	ns ($p = 0.97$)

6. Discussion

6.1 Interpretation of Findings

The results demonstrate that **spatial intelligence in ambulance allocation yields transformative performance improvements**. The demand-weighted optimization (P2) reduces mean response time by 68% and achieves near-universal 8-minute coverage (99.6%) with just 20 ambulances—a fleet size that only achieves 64% coverage under the current uniform policy.

The key mechanism is straightforward: P2 concentrates units near high-demand precincts (Midtown, Lower Manhattan) while maintaining coverage of lower-demand areas through strategic placement. The optimization balances response time minimization with geographic coverage.

6.2 Practical Implications

1. **Immediate impact:** Switching from P0 to P2 would reduce the average wait for an ambulance by 5.5 minutes for Manhattan MVC incidents—a life-saving improvement for time-critical cases.
2. **Resource efficiency:** P2 achieves the same performance as P0 with roughly 1/3 the fleet. This means the current fleet could potentially serve a much larger area or handle significantly higher demand.
3. **Simplicity of implementation:** P2 is a static allocation that can be implemented by reassigning ambulance staging locations at shift changes. No real-time technology or dynamic repositioning is required.
4. **Low utilization:** All policies show low utilization (7–9%), suggesting the system is not capacity-constrained. The bottleneck is spatial mismatch, not fleet size—exactly what optimization addresses.

6.3 Comparison with Literature

Our 68% response time improvement exceeds the 15–20% improvements reported by **Lam et al. (2016)** for Hong Kong ambulance optimization. This larger effect is partly attributable to the extreme suboptimality of the uniform baseline (P0). Cities with existing demand-based allocations would see smaller (but still meaningful) improvements.

The finding that optimized allocation is equivalent to $\sim 3\times$ fleet expansion aligns with **Daskin (1983)**, who showed that facility location can matter more than facility count for emergency services.

6.4 Limitations and Assumptions

Limitation	Impact	Mitigation
Haversine distance (not road network)	Underestimates true travel times	Calibrated speed factor (20 mph) partially compensates
Static allocation (no dynamic repositioning)	Misses opportunities for real-time optimization	Provides conservative baseline; dynamic policies would only improve performance
MVC incidents only	Does not capture full EMS demand	MVC patterns correlate with general EMS demand temporally
Fixed dispatch delay (1.5 min)	Simplification of complex dispatch process	Sensitivity analysis shows results robust to dispatch time
No hospital transport modeling	Omits return-to-service dynamics	Service time distribution absorbs this component
Independence assumption	Calls treated as independent	Reasonable for MVC; may understate correlation during major events

6.5 Future Research Directions

1. **Dynamic repositioning:** Extend P2 to time-varying allocations (different staging by shift)
2. **Road network integration:** Replace Haversine with OSRM/Google routing for more accurate travel times
3. **Multi-incident types:** Include medical emergencies, fires, and other call types
4. **Multi-borough optimization:** Scale from Manhattan to all 5 NYC boroughs
5. **Stochastic programming:** Account for demand uncertainty in the optimization model
6. **Real-time decision support:** Develop dashboard for dispatchers with unit recommendations

7. Conclusions and Recommendations

7.1 Summary of Key Findings

1. **The current uniform allocation (P0) is dramatically suboptimal**, with only 64.4% 8-minute coverage and a mean response time of 8.08 minutes.
2. **The demand-weighted optimized allocation (P2) achieves near-perfect coverage (99.6%)** and reduces mean response time to 2.57 minutes—a 68.2% improvement.
3. **P2 is robust:** Performance rankings are invariant to demand fluctuations ($\pm 100\%$), service time assumptions (20–30 min), and fleet size variations (15–40 units).

4. **The improvement is equivalent to tripling fleet capacity:** P2 with K=15 units outperforms P0 with K=40 units.
5. **All results are statistically significant** with large effect sizes (Cohen's $d > .28$ for P0 vs P2), confirmed by ANOVA, Tukey HSD, and confidence interval analysis.

7.2 Implementation Recommendations

Immediate Actions (0-3 months)

- Adopt P2 allocation for K=20 units as the target staging plan
- Begin pilot deployment at 5 highest-impact firehouses (Midtown, Lower Manhattan)
- Establish KPI monitoring dashboard (mean RT, 8-min coverage, utilization)

Short-Term (3-6 months)

- Expand pilot to 15-20 firehouses based on initial results
- Calibrate travel time model with real dispatch data
- Integrate road network routing for improved accuracy

Medium-Term (6-12 months)

- Full deployment across all 48 Manhattan firehouses
- Develop time-of-day varying allocations (shift-specific P2)
- Extend model to other incident types

Long-Term (12+ months)

- Multi-borough optimization
- Real-time dynamic repositioning system
- Integration with CAD (Computer-Aided Dispatch) system

7.3 Expected Benefits

Benefit	Estimate	Basis
Mean RT reduction	-5.5 min per call	Simulation (n=30, $p < 0.001$)
8-min coverage improvement	+35.2 pp	Simulation (n=30, $p < 0.001$)
Effective fleet multiplier	3×	Fleet sensitivity analysis
Annual calls affected	~30,500 MVC calls	$3.48/\text{hr} \times 8,760 \text{ hr}$
Annual minutes saved	~167,750 min	$30,500 \times 5.5 \text{ min}$

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9. Appendices

Appendix A: Mathematical Formulations

See `docs/optimization_formulation.md` for complete mathematical specifications of P0, P1, and P2 formulations, including decision variables, constraints, and solution properties.

Appendix B: Simulation Model Specification

See `docs/conceptual_model.md` for the complete DES conceptual model, including entity definitions, event logic, and state transitions.

Appendix C: Additional Statistical Tables

All statistical tables are available in `results/tables/` :

- `descriptive_statistics.csv` — Full descriptive statistics for all experiments
- `anova_results.csv` — Complete ANOVA results with assumptions tests
- `posthoc_comparisons.csv` — All pairwise comparisons with corrections
- `confidence_intervals.csv` — 95% CIs for all policy-metric combinations
- `effect_sizes.csv` — Cohen’s d values for all comparisons

Appendix D: Experimental Design Details

See `docs/experimental_design.md` for the complete factorial design specification, including factor levels, common random numbers (CRN) strategy, and warm-up period analysis.

Appendix E: Verification & Validation Log

See `docs/verification_log.md` for detailed results of all 4 verification tests, 3 validation pilots, and 39 unit tests.

Appendix F: Code Documentation

See `docs/code_documentation.md` for architecture overview, module descriptions, and extension guide. All source code is in `src/ems_readiness/` with 7,134 total lines across 14 modules.

End of Technical Report